

do you know its monthly cost? How much would it be to get short-term health insurance elsewhere?

5. Analyze your 401(k) plan options and obligations.

Do you have a loan associated with a 401(k) that you will need to pay off immediately? Should you leave the 401(k) with your employer's administrator while you decide where to transfer the funds? Do you need to transfer the assets immediately upon your separation from the company?

6. Learn the rules of unemployment insurance.

See if and when you are eligible for benefits (you should be eligible unless you were terminated for cause) and what the requirements are to receive payments. If you have been displaced as a result of increase in imports or offshore business, look into Trade Adjustment Assistance Program.

7. Set your professional and personal priorities.

Will you stay in the same town or will you relocate? Are you looking for a similar job in the same industry? Do you want to take a step forward and advance in responsibility or do

you want to move laterally, or take a step back in order to spend more time with your family or developing a business idea?

8. Investigate a new career.

You might decide that you really love the industry you've been working in, but this is a very good opportunity to consider other paths you might be interested in. Consider the time and resources it might take to change fields.

9. Check Salary.com or PayScale.com.

Determine if your professional goals, personal desires, and financial needs are synchronized with your expected compensation.

Why pause before making the job-search plunge? If you take a breath and do some financial assessments, you'll be more focused and more likely to get what you really want.

— Julie Rains

